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Session Agenda

1	The setup	MCP will not replace your connectors	5 min
2	Meet Project Orion	The scenario, the data, and the dashboard	5 min
3	Three tools, three jobs	What actually changes with MCP	12 min
4	Demo 1: the connector agent	Where a connector wins, and its ceiling	15 min
5	Two architectures	Today's demo setup vs. what you'd ship	8 min
6	Demo 2: the MCP agent	The server changes, the agent follows	18 min
7	When to reach for MCP	The decision framework and the honest warning	12 min
8	Take it home	The lab, the repo, and Q&A	15 min

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Learning Objectives

By the end of this session, you will be able to:

- Explain what actually changes**
Moving from a connector to an MCP server changes who owns the tools, not who decides to call them.
- Decide when MCP earns its cost**
Use two questions: how many agents share these tools, and how often do the tools change?
- Build it yourself**
A custom MCP server over SQL, GitHub's MCP server, a new tool rolled out without republishing the agent, and what changes for production.

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"MCP will not replace your connectors."

*The right question is not which tool is better.
The right question is: what does my agent need to do?*

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Introducing Project Orion

An enterprise team building a customer-facing web app. Mid-release cycle. Under pressure.

Release Readiness

52

/100

Was 85 three sprints ago

Sprint Completion

30%

Sprint 5, 14 of 45 pts done

Critical Blockers

3

open

Auth, dashboard, data sync

Velocity Trend

↓

Declining

Peak 43pts, now 23pts

Data lives in two places: SQL Server (sprint metrics) and GitHub (issues).
The agent needs to reason across both.

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Three Tools. Three Jobs.

Connector

What it is:

A prebuilt or custom Power Platform connector. Its actions are added and described in each agent.

Best for:

A known service that already has a connector.

REST API Tool

What it is:

Point the agent at an API and pick the endpoints. You describe each one, in each agent.

Best for:

Prototyping fast when no connector or MCP server exists.

MCP Server

What it is:

A server that publishes its own tools, descriptions and inputs. Agents discover them.

Best for:

The same tools shared by many agents, or APIs that change often.

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What Actually Changes With MCP

Connector

You define the tools, in every agent.

Each action and its inputs are described when you set up each agent.

When the API changes, you update every agent and republish it.

Close to the agent. Simple. Bounded.

VS

MCP Server

The server defines the tools, once.

Tools and their descriptions are discovered from the server at runtime.

Change the server, and every agent picks it up without being republished.

Shared across agents. Flexible. One more thing to run.

In both cases the agent decides when to call a tool. What changes is who owns the tools.

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"When many agents need the same tools, and those tools keep changing, that's your MCP signal."

Remember this: the question you should ask before every architectural decision.



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Demo 1 of 2: Connector Agent



Seven SQL tools and GitHub. Every tool added, configured and described by hand.

"What is the current release readiness score?"	SQL tool. Clean, accurate answer.
"What critical bugs are open in GitHub?"	GitHub tool. Matched to SQL by issue number.
"What is blocking the release?"	Both sources. The connector handles it.
"At our current pace, will we make the release?"	No forecast tool. It says so.

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Connector: Strengths vs. Cost of Change



Strengths

- Fast and lightweight
- Easy to maintain
- Predictable and testable
- No additional infrastructure
- Perfect for scoped, known data sources

To add a forecast, I'd have to

- Write a new stored procedure
- Add a new tool to the agent
- Set the server, database and procedure
- Write the description and parameter hints
- Test it
- Republish the agent**
- Repeat for every agent that needs it

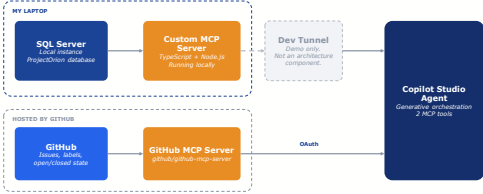
"Connectors did the reasoning. The cost is every change: edit, republish, repeat, in every agent."

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What You'll See Today: The Demo Setup

Everything on the left runs on my laptop. Built for a live demo, not for production.



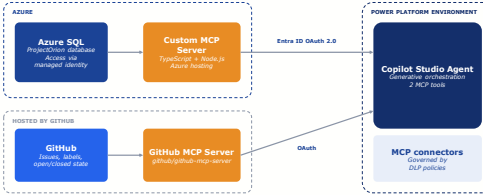
The tunnel only exists so a cloud agent can reach a database on my laptop.

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What You'd Ship: Target Cloud Design

Recommended design. Same agent, same tools. Only the hosting changes.



Every connection is authenticated, and policy governs every connection.

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Demo 2 of 2: MCP Agent

Same agent. The server changes. Nobody touches the agent.

"What is the current release readiness score?"	Same answer as Demo 1: 52, At Risk.
"What is blocking the release?"	Same blockers as Demo 1: parity.
"At our current pace, will we make the release?"	No forecast tool yet. Agent says so.
Flip the switch. New chat, same question.	New tool appears. Agent follows.

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MCP: Power and the Price You Pay

What You Gain

- Tools defined once, on the server
- Agents pick up changes without republishing
- Reusable across multiple agents
- Tool descriptions travel with the tools
- Scales to new tools without agent changes

What You Pay

- A developer must build and maintain it
- Infrastructure: hosting, identity, network
- Agent quality depends on the server's tool descriptions
- Higher complexity = higher surface area for failure
- Overkill when a connector would have done it
- Publishing to other tenants? Certification, and a fresh review for new tools

Complexity has a cost. Make sure your problem justifies it.

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When to Reach for MCP

ONE AGENT

STABLE TOOLS

CHANGING TOOLS

HOW MANY AGENTS USE THESE TOOLS? -->

MANY AGENTS

Connector Wins

Simple, governed, done.

Evaluate MCP

A shared custom connector may be enough. Weigh maintenance cost first.

Connector + Republish

With one agent, republishing is cheap.

MCP Is Right

Change it once. Every agent follows.

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"The most expensive architectural mistake is reaching for MCP because it sounds modern."

Complexity has a cost. Make sure your problem justifies it.

Connectors and plugins are not second-class citizens. They are the right tool for the right job, and that job is more common than you think.

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Everything You Need to Run This Yourself

Lab Guide & All Artifacts

- SQL setup script (ProjectOrion database)
- GitHub CLI script (15 issues, correlated to SQL)
- GitHub Copilot MCP Server scaffold prompt
- GitHub Copilot Next.js dashboard prompt
- Copilot Studio agent prompts (both versions)
- Step-by-step lab guide PDF

GitHub Repo



github.com/dgpblogster/project-orion-lab



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Questions?

"When many agents need the same tools, and those tools keep changing, that's your MCP signal!"

Lab guide + all artifacts: github.com/dgpblogster/project-orion-lab

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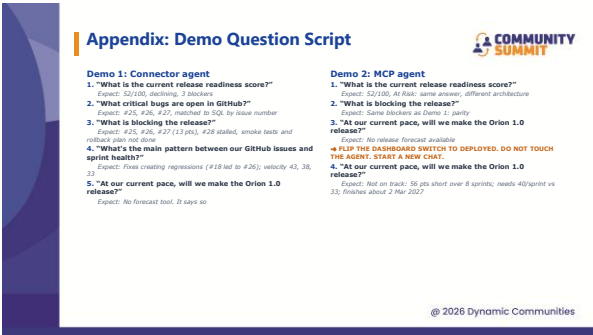
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